



THE LIFE OF THE SAMURAI



For about seven hundred years the Samurai were the honored knights of Japan. Fierce fighters, they had a tough training, becoming experts in fencing, wrestling, archery, and acrobatics, and they had a special code of behavior. The word samurai means “one who serves,” and

any Samurai worthy of the name was absolutely loyal to his lord, ready to obey any command without question.

However, although the Samurai were professional fighters, away from battle they were not violent men. The Samurai believed in Zen Buddhism, a religion that taught respect for all living things. The Samurai were also taught to love art and learning, taking pride in their skill at painting, writing poetry, and even flower-arranging.

The large, horned helmet was meant to terrify enemies as much as to protect its wearer.



Western merchants

When the Portuguese arrived in Japan in 1543, they brought guns with them. The guns changed the nature of warfare in the country completely.

